



CONSTRUCTION continues this week on the White House ballroom that is to replace the historic East Wing.

ICE tries to avoid outside oversight

Some contracts now assert that detention centers aren't subject to local or state laws.

BY ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — Immigration and Customs Enforcement is taking more and more steps to avoid oversight by local and state authorities of immigration detention centers amid growing complaints alleging unsanitary and unsafe conditions at the facilities.

The efforts to sidestep laws in California and elsewhere take many forms. In some instances, contracts have been changed to declare that the centers are simply not subject to certain local or state laws.

In other instances, ICE has purchased facilities owned and operated by private companies. Though the companies continue to run the centers holding thousands of detainees, federal ownership could aid their defense in the event of legal action.

George Zoley, the chief executive of GEO Group, which contracts with ICE to run detention centers in California and across the country, said as much to company shareholders this year. In an earnings call in May, he said that ownership bolsters the facilities' protection from "unwarranted litigation" around medical care and other detention conditions.

[See Oversight, A6]

Arcadia aims to counter China's influence

Ex-official pleaded guilty to acting as foreign agent

BY HANNAH FRY

With its top-tier schools, large residential lots and quiet living, generations of wealthy Chinese families have seen Arcadia as an ideal location to build a life in the United States.

The influx of investment and dedicated citizenry has helped the San Gabriel Valley suburb flourish economically and culturally, earning it the nickname the "Chinese Beverly Hills." Asian people, including many Chinese, make up the largest slice — roughly 59% — of the city's population of 54,000, according to the latest census.

"In the San Gabriel Valley, many of the cities that have done very well have done well because of immigration from Asia," Arcadia Mayor Paul Cheng said in an interview with The Times. "Arcadia has done very well."

But after months of scandal over a for-

mer council member accused of acting as an illegal agent of China, residents and city leaders are trying to reset the relationship and impose safeguards.

Many in Arcadia were shocked the Chinese government would try to wield influence in small-town politics. But there was also anger that such corruption is alleged to have occurred there.

"I think all of us are very sad over the issue, confused, and all of us feel bamboozled," Cheng said during a study session this month. "But at the same time, I do not want fear, uncertainty or doubt to stop our city from moving forward."

In response, Arcadia officials this month began what they say is a pioneering effort to determine how to protect local municipalities from influence by foreign governments. It comes at a time [See Arcadia, A7]

Sheinbaum's 'enemies list'?

Mexico leader's naming of journalists sparks outcry

BY PATRICK J. McDONNELL AND CECILIA SÁNCHEZ VIDAL

MEXICO CITY — In her previous job as mayor of Mexico City, Claudia Sheinbaum expressed outrage when a conservative critic proposed publicizing a list of prominent supporters of her leftist Morena political party.

"This is a fascist position," then-Mayor Sheinbaum said in 2021. "Who makes lists? McCarthyism. Nazism. Those are the ones who make lists."

Now, Sheinbaum finds her government accused of

creating its own blacklists — this time naming journalists, media outlets and others at odds with her administration.

The president is facing a firestorm of criticism after her chief counsel, Luisa María Alcalde, unveiled the lists last week at the National Palace. She assailed a digital "ecosystem" of bots and trolls that, she contends, picks up on journalistic criticisms to amplify "false narratives" against Mexico's leadership — or, as many critics call it, a "narco government."

Alcalde released two lists containing the names of 54 news outlets and journalists,

and another ledger of 32 opposition politicians and groups.

As journalists lined up to condemn the lists, Sheinbaum denied any attempt at censorship and came to the defense of her suddenly embattled chief counsel — who, the president said, never targeted anyone directly. The lists did not propose any official actions against those named.

"At no moment did she say ... 'They are the bad journalists,' or 'the journalists who attack us,'" the president said.

According to Sheinbaum, the point was that so- [See Lists, A3]

Justices weigh security role of the ballroom

Roberts lets work go on as court considers claim the 'complex' is 'vitaly required.'

BY DAVID G. SAVAGE AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court is weighing President Trump's claim that his new White House ballroom is urgently needed to protect him, his staff and guests from attacks by drones, terrorists and snipers.

On Friday, with a lower-court order about to go into effect halting construction on the controversial project, Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. decided that the court needed more time. He issued a temporary order pausing the case and allowing construction to continue while the justices decide on a pending legal challenge.

Last week, Trump administration lawyers described the East Wing ballroom as an "integrated military complex" that is "vitaly required by national security." They argued that a judge's order blocking further construction threat-

ened the safety of the president and must be overturned. They also said the project is nearly two-thirds completed.

At issue is whether the president acting on his own may build a huge new ballroom complex that is expected to dwarf the historic Executive Mansion.

It is a confrontation over the boundaries of executive power at a moment when Trump has repeatedly tested the ability of courts, Congress and independent institutions to constrain his agenda.

Trump bulldozed the historic East Wing before the courts had resolved whether the administration had the authority to proceed, leaving opponents to argue the project could become effectively irreversible before judicial review was complete.

The National Trust for Historic Preservation sued in December and argued that the president had overstepped his authority.

U.S. District Judge Richard Leon agreed and ordered a stop to the above-ground construction — that is, on the ballroom. He said the work on the underground bunker may pro- [See Ballroom, A6]

Many in state are losing healthcare

California's uninsured rate could almost double by 2030, wiping out gains.

BY KRISTEN HWANG

Two years ago, California hit a milestone decades in the making: Nearly every person in the state qualified for health insurance, regardless of immigration status and income, pushing the state's insured rate to a record 95%. Now that progress is unraveling.

Facing budget shortfalls and new federal restrictions, state leaders have begun rolling back the coverage system they built. Analysis at the UC Berkeley Labor Center and UCLA Center for Health Policy Research project California's uninsured rate could nearly double, to almost 15%, by 2030.

"I knew it was going to be

bad, but seeing that doubling was shocking to me," said Miranda Dietz, director of the labor center's health-care program.

An estimated 2.2 million people could lose insurance over the next four years from combined state and federal cuts, the researchers found. The losses will fall hardest on undocumented immigrants and low-income Californians, with the uninsured rate more than doubling among Black and Asian Californians. The southern part of the state will bear the brunt, driven by its larger share of low-income and immigrant residents.

Many Californians remember how difficult it was to get healthcare before the state expanded and improved insurance options.

In 2008, Kandi Hill had just given birth to her third child. When she started throwing up and experiencing irregular menstrual cy- [See Insurance, A7]

Voices MARY MCNAMARA CULTURE CRITIC

Harry and Meghan's move is a PR bonanza

The Duke and Duchess of Sussex's exit from Montecito is not at all surprising



PRINCE HARRY and Meghan Markle are reportedly returning to the U.K. six years after the couple left amid a family feud.

RONALD MARTINEZ Getty Images

Honestly, it was probably the traffic. Have you ever tried to get into, or out of, Montecito in the summer, or virtually any other time of year? The 101 has long been a bottleneck nightmare as it approaches Santa Barbara and the years-long project to widen the freeway has only made it worse.

One may be rich and famous enough to skip the queue at a restaurant or Disneyland, but traffic cones and lane closures bow to no man.

The "shocking" news that Prince Harry and Meghan Markle, the Duke and Duchess of Sussex, will be moving back to the U.K. appears to have left many people baffled, their "burning questions" littering the media landscape.

Why would Harry, who as recently as last year said he could not imagine returning with his family to a land where they were so relentlessly dogged by a vitriolic press, and Meghan, an actor who built a Netflix series and business off the fecundity of California's 12-month growing season, ditch the West Coast for a country where she faced such inarguable racism?

[See Sussexes, A8]



JEFF CHIU Associated Press

REPLACING SWALWELL

Progressive state Sen. Aisha Wahab defeats the president of BART's board to serve out the term of the former congressman. CALIFORNIA, B4

Indicted by U.S., but back in office

Mexican Gov. Rubén Rocha Moya of Sinaloa denounces charges of collaboration with a drug cartel. WORLD, A3

Weather

Sunny, very warm. L.A. Basin: 93/70. B8

Markets

Opinion Voices A12

Top editor fired at military paper

Stars and Stripes' Erik Slavin says insubordination was reason. BUSINESS, A12

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